of letter, since who knows where and when such letters can surface or be somehow published—not now, but in the future—and any changes in the course of events are possible. The appearance of such a document could cause irreparable harm to my political career in the future. This is why we request that you take this letter back."

Dobrynin, who reported Robert Kennedy's words to Moscow, found himself obliged to take the letter back. On November 1, the Soviet ambassador delivered another message from Khrushchev to the attorney general. The Soviet leader trusted the president's word. The possibility of an immediate public scandal over the missiles in Turkey was avoided.[13]

Khrushchev had a lot of his own explaining to do. If Kennedy had to keep his political concession secret, Khrushchev was in no position to explain to his own people and the world at large why he had abandoned his demand to remove the American missiles from Turkey. He had to lie in order to make his deal work. Khrushchev probably understood quite well that a leak would make it impossible for Kennedy to keep his word. Not surprisingly, given his style and temperament, Khrushchev declared himself the victor in the crisis. He had allegedly achieved his goal of saving Cuba and did not need his missiles on the island for geostrategic reasons, as he could hit the United States from the USSR. Last but not least, he had saved the world from the nuclear war that Castro was ready to ignite.

The first opportunity to explain himself came on October 29, the day after he accepted Kennedy's conditions, when a Czechoslovak delegation led by the country's communist leader, Antonín Novotný, visited Moscow. The master of the Kremlin remained true to the word he had given Kennedy and did not mention the Cuba-Turkey swap to Novotný and his colleagues, although he hinted that "[t]hrough certain persons who they knew were in contact with us, they made it clear they would be grateful if we helped them get out of this conflict." Khrushchev accepted Kennedy's argument about his political inability to make a public deal on Turkey. "We understood that these questions are too far removed from the concrete situation in the Caribbean and Cuba, that Kennedy could not answer them because he would have also to consult with other members of NATO, and the situation was too serious for us to postpone its solution."[14]